ASSEMBLY POLLS 2022

HIMACHAL PRADESH

UPHILL BATTLE

AS THE POLL CAMPAIGN ENTERS THE FINAL STRETCH, WILL HIMACHAL BUCK THE TREND AND GIVE THE BJP A SECOND TERM, OR WILL THE CONGRESS FIND REDEMPTION?

By Anilesh S. Mahajan in Shimla



CHARGED UP Pratibha Singh campaigning in Chopal, Shimla, Nov. 2

AS THE CAVALCADE winds down the road in Bilaspur district in Himachal Pradesh, a much-garlanded Pratibha Singh, the Congress state unit chief, steps out to loud cheers from supporters. The widow of six-time chief minister Virbhadra Singh is in the region to canvass for party candidates, in this case Rajesh Dharmani in Ghumarwin. The rallies and roadshows have gone off well, considering that Bilaspur is a bastion of the rival BJP, and home to the party's national chief J.P. Nadda. The Congress is yet to declare a chief ministerial candidate, which is perhaps why Pratibha has been going the extra mile in her campaign. A Congress win should make her one of the favourites for the top post.

The state goes to the polls on November 12 to elect 68 members to the assembly. No party has managed a repeat mandate since 1985, which should boost Congress hopes, despite the fact that it will not have Virbhadra and his organisational skills to fall back on this time. The Himachal election is crucial for both the Congress and BJP. The Congress will be hoping to break a long losing streak; it will also be a welcome gift for new party president Mallikarjun Kharge. For the BJP's Nadda, who is eyeing a second term/ extension as party chief in January, a favourable result will only bolster his case.

Pratibha, meanwhile, is addressing 4-5 rallies every day. As expected, the conversation mostly revolves around "Raja sahib", as her late husband was fondly known, and his contributions to the state. Virbhadra died in July 2021 of Covid-related complications—the sympathy wave worked well for the Congress during last year's bypolls, handing it all three assembly seats and the Mandi Lok Sabha seat for Pratibha. Analysts, though, are not so sure if it will have the same purchase in the coming election. Son Vikramaditya Singh, the sitting MLA from Shimla Rural seems confident. So much so that, while talking to INDIA TODAY on a trek to village Parihana near Dhami in his constituency, he says, "The party wants her to campaign freely and not be confined to a single seat."

A CONGRESS WIN WILL ENDORSE NEW CHIEF KHARGE; A BJP VICTORY WILL BOOST NADDA'S CHANCES FOR A SECOND STINT AS PARTY CHIEF

Chief Minister Jairam Thakur believes his Congress rivals face a "tough situation". "Their best-known leader is no more. The party is beleaguered, trying to keep its leaders together. The BJP will benefit from having a scattered Congress," he says. He is confident he will break the jinx this time of incumbent parties not getting a repeat mandate in Himachal. "*Hum riwaaz badlenge* (We will change the custom)," he says, quoting the party's new poll slogan.

REBELS IN THE RANKS

What CM Thakur omits to mention is that his party is plagued by rebels too. Once ticket selection was over, it became evident that the CM was the new satrap